

Towns' fluoride votes echo a larger debate

Anger, distrust drove Swansea from treatment

By Jason Laughlin

GLOBE STAFF

If Robert F. Kennedy Jr. is confirmed as President-elect Trump's health secretary, he would likely encourage the nation's public drinking water supplies to look more like the town of Swansea than its neighbor, Somerset.

In 2023, the two communities near Rhode Island each held votes on whether to fluoridate its public drinking water.

Somerset residents voted to keep fluoridation, but Swansea did not, although in each town, fewer than 100 voters decided on a policy that could affect thousands of their neighbors.

And, in an echo of a national debate sparked by Kennedy, in Swansea, the drive to overturn the town's fluoride policy was driven by frustration with the government and distrust of health care experts.

"They didn't seem to have any sway with the residents," said Lisa Martelly, the head of the Swansea Water District's Board of Commissioners, who said that regardless of decades

FLUORIDE, Page A7

A naturally occurring mineral, fluoride was first added to public water 80 years ago this month in Grand Rapids, Mich.

Nearly three-quarters of the country receives fluoridated water, but in Mass., about

58%

of the population does

A study found children from Springfield enrolled in MassHealth had

44%

more claims for dental procedures than those in Lowell, which does fluoridate

500,000

about the number of people in Massachusetts that get their water from private wells, which can have naturally occurring fluoride in them

Confirmation hearings expected to offer clues

Nominees will share spotlight amid new dynamics, strategies in Senate

By Tal Kopan

GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When confirmation hearings kick off this week, more than just President-elect Trump's nominees will be on display. It will be the public's first glimpse of the new political reality in Washington — and a look at the strategies each party will deploy as they go toe-to-toe.

Democrats will be looking to thread the needle between op-

posing Trump — perhaps even tripping up confirmation of some controversial nominees — and courting back part of their base of support that apparently swung toward Trump in November. Republicans will be trying to balance confirming Trump's nominees at a rapid clip while maintaining their independence and ability to object to anyone they find unsuitable.

The entire drama will play

out in five-minute increments, as senators take their turns questioning the nominees at the made-for-TV hearings that will shape many Americans' first impressions of the new Trump administration.

Several of the more high-profile and controversial nominations will have hearings this week, including defense secretary nominee Pete Hegseth, attorney general nominee Pam Bondi, homeland security secretary nominee and South Dakota Governor Kristi Noem, and

HEARINGS, Page A6

A SEARCH WITH NO ANSWERS



BRANDON BELL/GETTY IMAGES

With a picturesque Malibu beach as a backdrop, Patrick O'Neal sifted through his home after it was destroyed by the Palisades wildfire. "I'm trying to figure out where I am in the house ... I think I'm standing in my dad's bathroom," he said. "To be honest, I don't even know what I'm looking for." Firefighters and Los Angeles officials braced for another round of ferocious winds that are expected to further fuel the wildfires there. **A2.**

Next stop for MBTA's housing plan: a fiercely divided Needham

By Andrew Brinker

GLOBE STAFF

NEEDHAM — On this town's low-slung main drag, there's a new addition to the charming streetscape. Political signs. A lot of them.

There's a pair of "Yes for Needham!" signs tucked into planters in front of the bustling French Press Bakery and Cafe. Just down the street, a bold-lettered "Vote No" sign is lodged in the frozen front yard of a Victorian-style single-family home.

Residents of this suburban town of 32,000 will head to the polls Tuesday to decide what has been perhaps the most controversial politi-

cal question Needham has faced in decades: Whether or not to approve a plan to comply with the requirements of a state housing law and open the town up to more development.

It is the only time in recent memory a political issue has been so controversial that signs have populated store fronts and yards in such abundance, said Select Board member Catherine Dowd. Members of the campaigns behind these dueling signs are so motivated to sell their message, they bundled into coats and scarves and gathered in front of town hall on Saturday toting more signs and reminding residents to vote.

NEEDHAM, Page A7



TAYLOR COESTER FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

A vote on whether to ease Needham's zoning laws to allow more housing will be held Tuesday. Residents on both sides of the issue rallied Saturday at the town common.

Judge orders supremacists to pay \$2.7m to Black victim

By Shelley Murphy

GLOBE STAFF

A federal judge on Monday ordered the white supremacist group Patriot Front and its leader to pay more than \$2.7 million in damages to a Black musician for violating his civil rights by attacking him in Boston's Back Bay in 2022 during a "flash march" through the city over the Fourth of July weekend.

The assault on Charles M. Murrell III as he walked along Dartmouth Street on his way to the Boston Public Library to play his saxophone was encouraged by the group's leader, Thomas Rousseau, who led the marchers and "glorified" the attack afterward by celebrating a video clip that had been posted online, US District Judge Indira Talwani wrote in a 27-page decision.

The video clip showed the group "pinning Murrell against the light post and pushing him into the busy road, to promote the view that non-white individuals like Murrell should be subordinated to white people," Talwani wrote. Murrell suffered injuries to his hand that make it difficult for him to continue to support himself by playing music, as well as psychological trauma, and has "essentially been in survival mode" since the attack, she said.

"I thought I was going to die," said Murrell, 37, while testifying in US District Court in Boston last October during a hearing to determine how much

PATRIOT FRONT, Page A10



Charles M. Murrell III



DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

New head coach

Mike Vrabel (above) kicked off a new era for the Patriots with pledges to hold the players, coaches accountable. **C1.**

The number of Americans who develop dementia will double over the next 35 years to about 1 million annually by 2060, according to a report. **A2.**

The bankruptcy filing of the for-profit owner of two Rhode Island hospitals echoes the Steward Health Care debacle, Larry Edelman writes. **D1.**



Advance to glow

Tuesday: Some sun, breezy. High 31-36, low 22-27.
Wednesday: More sun, wind. High 28-33, low 15-20.
Sunrise: 7:11. Sunset: 4:36.
Weather and comics, **D5-6.**
Obituaries, **C9.**

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